

Episode 38: Once Upon a Time... (28) – The Long Battle Over "Colour Direction" Credits, Part 2

Did you catch *Hakaba Kitaro*, which started broadcasting last week?

Right after the broadcast ended, I immediately went around looking at reactions on the web (including 2ch (laugh)). I think honest reactions are really those first impressions right after watching something. When time passes and you see other people's reactions, there's often a tendency for humans to correct and reorganise their own thoughts. So I kept clicking around doing searches until about 3 AM (laugh).

It was received with mixed reactions, pretty much as expected, which was reassuring in a way. I hope it becomes a topic of conversation in various ways and many people watch it. Thanks to this, we apparently got a good 4.8% viewership rating for the first episode, which makes me very happy. Even so, we just need to continue through the series without wavering from our centre, keeping our focus steady.

By the way, there was actually content checking by the TV station at the storyboard stage, and we got feedback about expressions that would be problematic for broadcast.

For episode #1, things like the frog's eyeball stretching out with a squishy sound were NG (← the sound is there though), showing the hand that throws (shoves) baby Kitaro was NG, naturally hitting the gravestone with his eye was NG, showing the lesions under Kitaro's father's bandages was NG, naturally blood spattering was also NG, and so on. The blood bank storyline from the original, as well as the part from the original where Kitaro smokes cigarettes freely, were also removed from the setting in light of various contemporary circumstances.

Some feedback mentioned that the "expressions were mild," but there were those circumstances. After all, we're making *Hakaba Kitaro* as a TV broadcast production.

It's truly unfortunate that it's not a nationwide broadcast, but starting this week, people in Kansai and Tokai regions should be able to watch it too. Please give it a try (^_^).

Well then.

Continuing the story about "Colour Direction" credits.

I wanted to somehow get a "Colour Direction" credit created in the ending, but I didn't know how to go about it. I had no idea who I should ask at the time. So for starters, I went to my direct supervisor, the finishing department manager.

"Um, I'd like to have a 'Colour Direction' credit created in the TV series ending..." I said.

"Hm? That sort of thing is decided policy, so no," said the manager.

"Huh? Why not? Who decides this policy?"

My switch flipped and I launched into a one-sided exposition of my theory to the manager. The folly of youth (bitter laugh).

"That sort of thing is..." The manager was momentarily taken aback, but still tried to calm me down while explaining how difficult it would be. I still wasn't convinced, but when the manager said "I'll consider it as a future matter for now," I couldn't do anything more and retreated.

This was during the time I was working on *Saint Seiya* (聖闘士星矢). In the end, that discussion just faded away, and for the next 10 years, there was no "Colour Direction" credit in TV series endings (bitter laugh).

Around that time, my work gradually shifted from TV to theatrical and video productions. So I thought, "Maybe weekly TV series are impossible, but standalone theatrical works might work somehow?" I was stubbornly persistent (bitter laugh).

Unlike TV series, theatrical version ending credits properly had a "Inspection" credit category from before, and I had my name listed under "Inspection" for *Theatrical GeGeGe no Kitaro: The Great Yokai War* (劇場版 ゲゲゲの鬼太郎 妖怪大戦争) and *Theatrical Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods* (劇場版 聖闘士星矢 神々の熱き戦い). So I thought, couldn't we attach "Colour Direction" to that "Inspection" for the credit? Actually, the work content of "Inspection" was "Colour Direction" and "Finishing Inspection," so if we could clarify that by having it read "Colour Direction Inspection," maybe I could push for that and make it work somehow? That was my strategy (laugh).

So this time I used various means... well, it's not like I had political power, but whenever the opportunity arose, I'd explain the purpose to various people, building understanding among related parties through what you might call networking, and I worked at it more persistently. As a result, I was able to get my name listed in the ending of *Theatrical Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth* (劇場版 聖闘士星矢 真紅の少年伝説) under the "Colour Direction Inspection" credit!

This was quite moving. Especially since *Theatrical Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth* was a work with strong obsession and emotional investment in colour, when "Colour Direction Inspection: Tsujita Kunio" appeared in the ending, I got all warm and fuzzy inside. I haven't investigated every single old production, but I think this was probably the first time a "Colour Direction" credit appeared in a Toei production (sorry if I'm wrong).

Once a precedent or format is established, it gets carried forward. For a while after this, "Colour Direction Inspection" became the established credit for theatrical production endings.